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# Slice of history

India scalps a Davis Cup win after 32 years, courtesy some **spirited** performances by Sumit Nagal and Dhakshineswar Suresh.

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**H**ome to brands such as Rolex, Omega and Swatch, the Swiss city of Biel is also referred to as the 'world capital of watchmaking'. It is, therefore, a little poetic that India's long wait for a Davis Cup win on European soil ended in a place with such a strong connection to time.

Three-time runner-up India took down Switzerland 3-1 in a World Group I tie at the Swiss Tennis Arena on September 12-13 to secure a place in next year's first round of Qualifiers. It also marked the nation's first triumph in Europe since Leander Paes and Ramesh Krishnan pulled off a stunning come-from-behind 3-2 quarterfinal win over France in Frejus, Cannes, in 1993.

The victory over Switzerland this month wasn't as dramatic as the one against France 32 years ago.

A year after his controversial decision to field N. Sriram Balaji, a doubles specialist, in a singles rubber against Sweden — a World Group I tie which India eventually lost 4-0 — captain Rohit Rajpal made another bold call. He preferred Dhakshineswar Suresh, initially a

reserve, over India No. 2 Aryan Shah and India No. 3 Karan Singh for the opening singles.

The gamble paid off, as World No. 626 Dhakshineswar, a 6ft 5in, thin-framed player with a booming serve, beat World No. 155 Jerome Kym 7-6(5), 6-3 on a fast indoor hard court. Dhakshineswar hit nine aces, saved seven break points and converted the first opportunity he got to take a decisive 5-3 lead in the second set against Kym, who reached the third round of this year's U.S. Open.

Sumit Nagal, back in the squad after two years, made it 2-0 for India at the end of Day 1 with a 6-3, 7-6(4) win over former World No. 47 Marc-Andrea Huesler.

While Balaji and Rithvik Choudary Bollipalli lost to Jakub Paul and Dominic Stricker 6-7(3), 6-4, 7-5 in the doubles rubber, India No. 1 Nagal completed the job with a flawless 6-1, 6-3 win over 18-year-old Henry Bernet, the junior Australian Open champion making his Davis Cup debut.

India returns to the Qualifiers for the first time since a 1-3 loss in Croatia in 2020.



**Giant strides:** Dhakshineswar Suresh beat World No. 155 Jerome Kym, hitting nine aces and saving seven break points on the way. AP